

The money was there. The picture wasn't.

What follows is a real engagement. The client name and identifying details have been removed. The work, the scope, and the outcomes are not.

Sector: Founder-led product and services business

Scale: £4M–£8M annual revenue, two operating entities

Engagement type: Financial architecture, reporting infrastructure & cash governance

Duration: Extended embedded engagement

THE SITUATION

It wasn't a cash problem. It was a visibility problem.

The founder had built something real. Revenue was growing. The team was expanding. On paper, the business was working.

But the founder was operating blind. Month-end numbers arrived three to four weeks late — long after the decisions that depended on them had already been made, or avoided. Cash forecasting was done in a spreadsheet that one person maintained and nobody else understood. Intercompany transactions between the two entities were tracked informally, if at all.

By the time a problem became visible, it had already compounded. The business was not in crisis. But it was one bad quarter away from one.

The founder wasn't making bad decisions. They were making decisions with bad information — which is a different problem entirely, and a more solvable one.

When I was brought in, the stated problem was 'we need better reporting.' The actual problem was that the financial architecture of the business had never been built. There were transactions, accounts, and a bookkeeper. There was no system.

THE DIAGNOSIS

What I found.

The engagement began with a full financial architecture review — not an audit, but a structural assessment of how financial information was generated, routed, interpreted, and acted upon across the business.

Three categories of failure were consistent across both entities:



- Cash visibility failure — actual cash position was unknown in real time. The founder's mental model of the bank balance was based on memory and approximation, not live data. Forecasting was retrospective, not predictive.
- Reporting architecture collapse — month-end close was a manual reconciliation exercise that took weeks and produced a backwards-looking snapshot nobody had time to interrogate. The numbers arrived too late to change outcomes.
- Intercompany opacity — the two entities traded with each other and shared costs, but this was not modelled, governed, or visible. Profitability at the entity level was unknown. The group-level picture was unreliable.

THE WORK

What I built.

The intervention was not advisory. It was architectural. This is not a list of recommendations. These are things that were designed, built, and embedded.

Cash governance infrastructure

A rolling 13-week cash flow model was designed and operationalised — not a static template, but a living instrument that was owned, updated, and interrogated weekly. Cash position, receivables timing, and upcoming commitments were made visible in a single view the founder could use to make decisions. Variance analysis was built in so that gaps between forecast and actual became structural learning, not surprises.

Month-end close architecture

The close process was redesigned from the ground up. Responsibilities were assigned, sequences were defined, and dependencies were eliminated where possible. Month-end close moved from a four-week manual exercise to a structured seven-day close with defined owners at each stage. Management accounts were delivered while they were still relevant.

Intercompany framework

The financial relationship between the two entities was documented, priced, and governed. Intercompany recharges were formalised. Group-level and entity-level profitability became separately visible for the first time. The founder could now see where value was being created and where it was being absorbed.

Executive financial reporting

A single-page weekly financial dashboard was designed for the founder — cash, revenue run-rate, aged debtors, and forward commitments, presented without noise. Monthly board-level reporting was structured to support decision-making rather than document history. Reporting went from something that happened after the fact to something that shaped what happened next.

Chart of accounts and bookkeeping governance



The chart of accounts was restructured so that the data produced by day-to-day bookkeeping was actually useful at the management level. Coding conventions were defined, reviewed, and embedded with the bookkeeping function. The garbage-in problem was addressed at its source.

THE OUTCOME

What changed.

The founder now knows their cash position every week, not every quarter. Month-end close is a process, not a crisis. The two entities are financially legible — to the founder, to future investors, and to any acquirer doing diligence.

The business did not become more profitable because of this work. It became governable. And a governable business is one that can be scaled, financed, and eventually sold — on the founder's terms, not under duress.

Most founders underestimate the cost of financial opacity. It doesn't show up as a line item. It shows up as bad timing, missed leverage, and decisions made on instinct when the data was there all along.

This engagement covered what would typically be distributed across a fractional CFO, a management accountant, a finance systems consultant, and a reporting analyst. It was delivered as a single embedded engagement — working inside the business, not consulting from a distance.

IF THIS IS FAMILIAR

What to do next.

If the pattern in this story is recognisable — if your numbers arrive too late to act on, if your cash position is more estimate than fact, if your business is growing but your financial architecture hasn't grown with it — the problem you have is structural.

That is solvable. But it requires working at the level of architecture, not activity.

Enquire at kaylee-jane.com

This isn't for everyone. If it's for you, you'll know.

